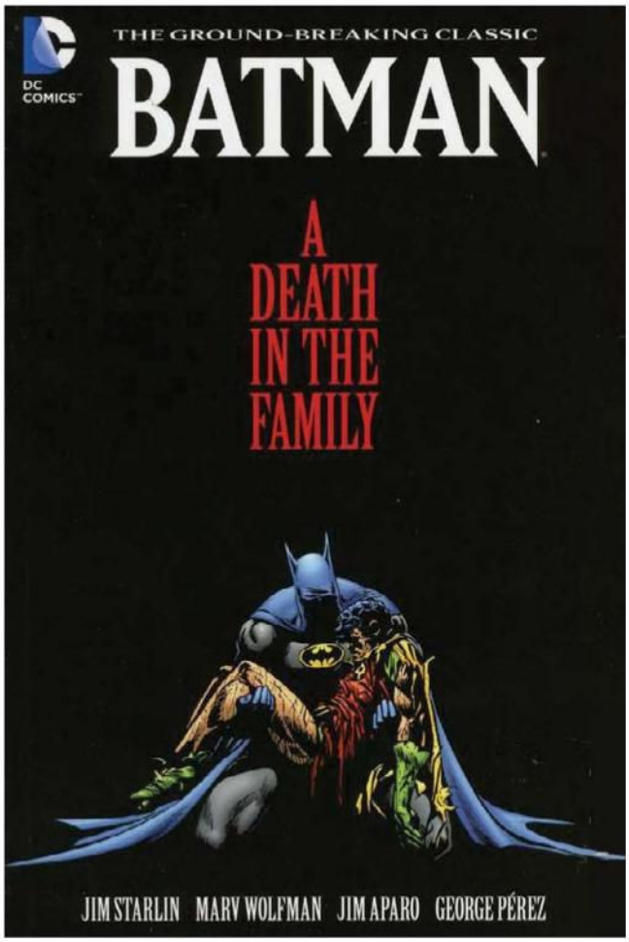


BATMAN: A DEATH IN THE FAMILY

Details **Originally published** Batman #426-429 (1988-89) **Publisher** DC **Writer** Jim Starlin **Artists** Jim Aparo, Mike DeCarlo, John Constanza, Adrienne Roy **Collected in** Batman: A Death In The Family **Available digitally** Comixology, Kindle

If there's a book on this list you'll struggle with, it's this one.

Not because of the brutal punchline either, but because of how it tries, and fails, to engage with social issues. The sight of billionaire Bruce Wayne looking sad and dutiful on the streets of Ethiopia is exactly as bad as you think it is, and the Joker aligning with Iran in the big finale is shocking for all the wrong reasons. You can see where they're aiming, and the book gets marks for trying but these days it reads as crass at best and offensive at worst.

But you're here to watch Robin die.

And he does. And it's brutal, and horrifying and a moment that changes the DC universe forever. This is the first time Batman fails and for all the story's legion of failures, the emotional weight of the death is essential reading.



"YOU'RE HERE TO WATCH ROBIN DIE"

ALL-STAR SUPERMAN

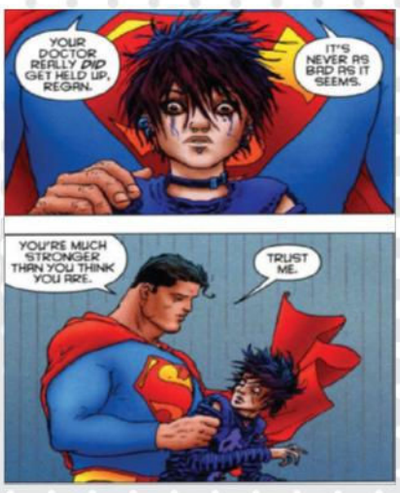
Details **Originally published** All-Star Superman #1-12 (2005-08) **Publisher** DC **Writer** Grant Morrison **Artist** Frank Quitely **Collected in** All-Star Superman (£13.99) **Available digitally** Comixology

Are superheroes still relevant?

All-Star Superman doesn't waste time asking that question. Instead, it sets out exactly why and how we need them.

The premise: Superman is dying and wants to complete twelve tasks before he dies, many of which involve old friends and enemies (impressively synthesising seven decades of continuity).

Whether he's operating on a cosmic scale or talking to a single person, Superman's primary mission is to help people. For instance, he saves a planet, fights a living sun and convinces a teenage girl not to commit suicide. It's a hopeful, moving comic that uplifts rather than opting for darkness or violence.



Given that he's dying, though, even Superman can't stand up to mortality – except, of course, he can, as long as Superman stories are being told. That's why we need superheroes: to inspire us to help those who need it and stand for something greater than ourselves.

